

AUSTRALIA'S DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSFORMATION FROM 1996 TO 2016

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Table of Contents

<i>Introduction.....</i>	<i>3</i>
<i>1. National Evolution</i>	<i>4</i>
1.1 Population Growth & State Contributions	4
1.2 National Ageing & Retiree Gender Split.....	5
1.3 State-by-State Age Structure Comparison	5
<i>2. Most High Populated COB Analysis</i>	<i>7</i>
2.1 Comparison of Australian-born and Immigrant Population Trends	7
2.2 India Leads a Migration Surge, While Italy’s Community Contracts	8
2.3 New South Wales and Victoria Dominate, But New Zealanders Buck the Trend	8
2.4 Clustering vs. Dispersion: Which Communities Spread Out?	8
<i>3. Interesting Aspects: Migration Trends and Demographic Profiles</i>	<i>9</i>
3.1 Asia’s Migrant Boom Fuels National Growth	10
3.2 Working-Age Migrants: A Critical Workforce Share	11
3.3 Demographic Contrasts Among Migrant Cohorts	12
3.4 Emerging Patterns and Policy Implications.....	12
<i>4. Synthesis & Implications</i>	<i>13</i>
4.1 Synthesis.....	13
4.2 Implications	13
<i>Conclusion</i>	<i>14</i>
<i>References</i>	<i>15</i>

Introduction

Understanding demographic change is essential for Australia's public-sector planning. Between 1996 and 2016, shifts in age structure, migration patterns and regional growth placed new demands on housing, health care, education and labour markets. This report uses the "AUS_COB_ABS" dataset a comprehensive ABS extract of estimated resident populations by state, age (5-year bands), sex and country of birth to build three Power BI dashboards. These interactive visual tools enable stakeholders to explore national and state trends; comparisons among the nine largest overseas-born cohorts plus Australia; and deeper "storytelling" on migration dynamics. Power BI's filtering, drill-through and custom measures (e.g., latest-year totals, cohort shares) ensure both high-level overviews and granular analyses are intuitive and self-explanatory.

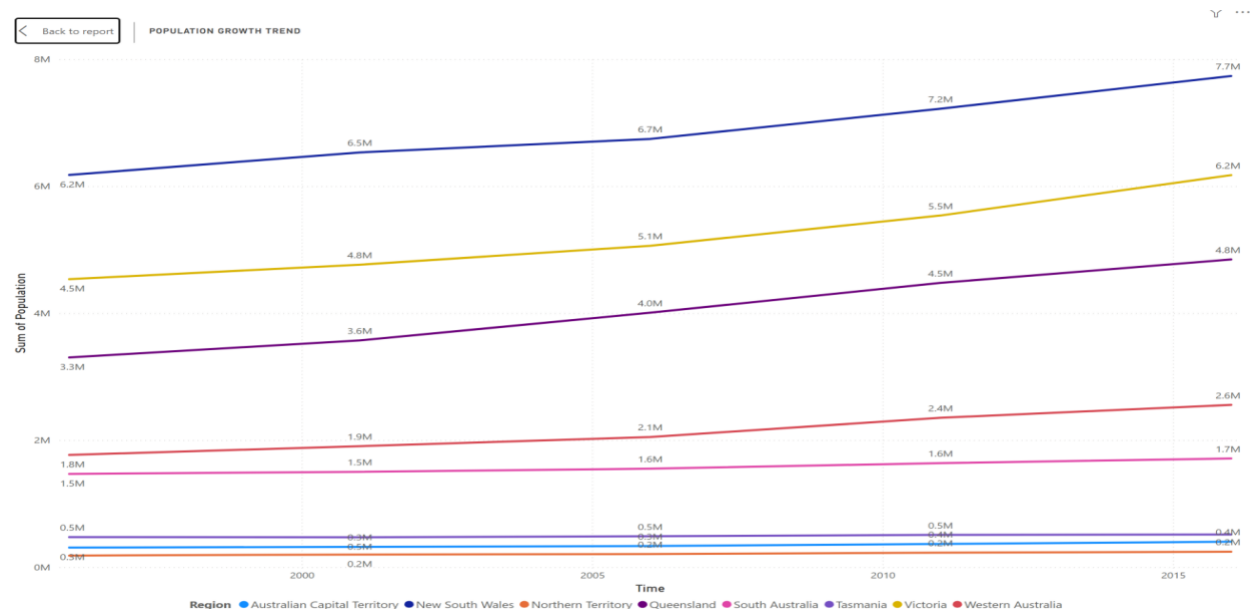
1. National Evolution

Figure 1. Population Trend & Distribution



1.1 Population Growth & State Contributions

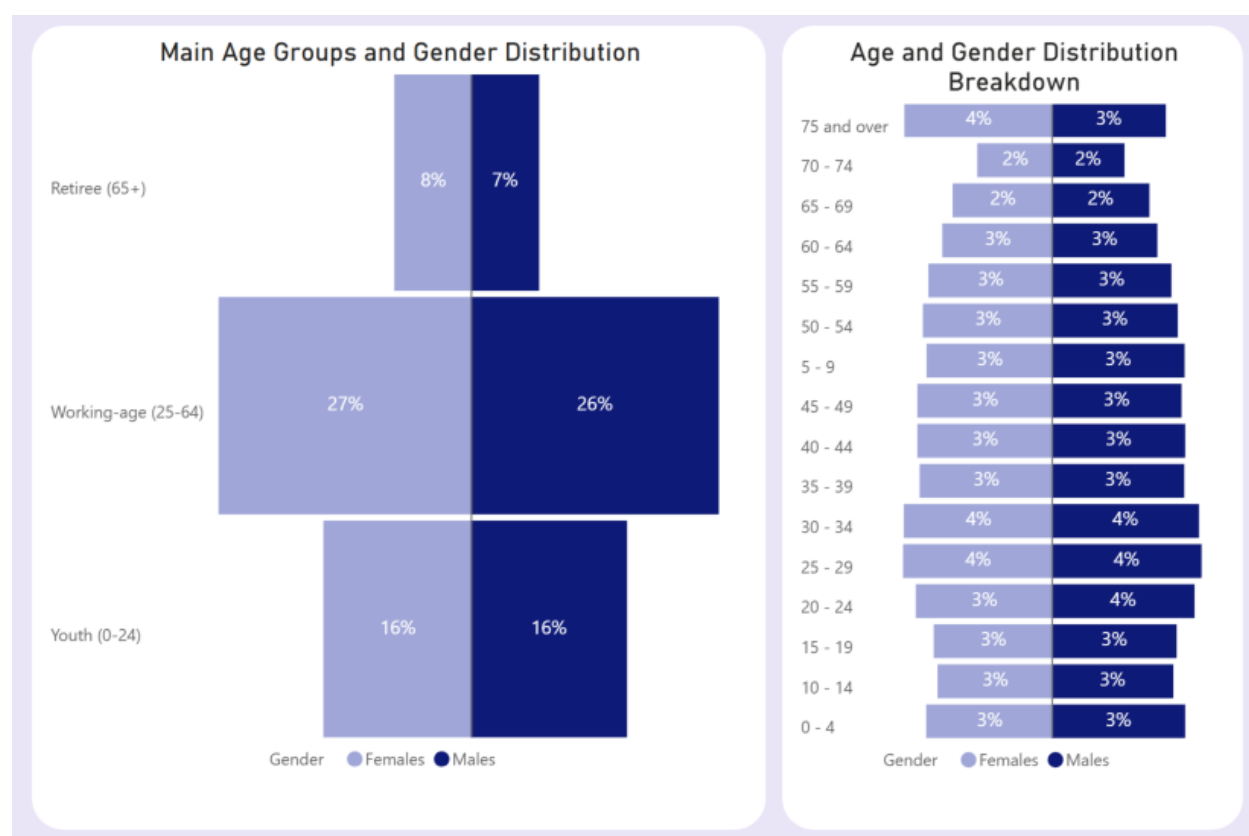
Figure 2. Population Growth Trend



Between 1996 and 2016, Australia's total estimated-resident population rose from 18.23 million to 24.19 million, an increase of 6.96 million (35 %). However, that growth was far from evenly distributed. Victoria led all states, adding 1 637 840 people over the two decades, closely followed by New South Wales (+ 1 556 630) and Queensland (+ 1 541 800). In contrast, Tasmania and the Northern Territory saw only modest gains of 40 830 and 60 170, respectively. This disparity underscores the continued magnetism of Australia's two largest states for internal and overseas migrants alike, while the smaller jurisdictions experience much slower net increases.

1.2 National Ageing & Retiree Gender Split

Figure 3. Age and Gender Distribution



In 2016, the population aged 65 and over comprised roughly 15.2 % of all Australians. Breaking that down by sex reveals that 8.09 % of the total population were female retirees, compared to 7.10 % who were male retirees. The slightly higher proportion of older women reflects both longer life expectancy and the legacy of earlier migration patterns. Despite this aging trend, the combined working-age cohort (25 - 64 yrs) remained dominant at around 50 %, highlighting a balanced demographic profile even as the retiree share edges upward each census.

1.3 State-by-State Age Structure Comparison

In 2016, the share of working-age residents (25 - 64 years) ranged markedly across Australia's eight jurisdictions, from a youthful high of 57.8 % in the Northern Territory down to 50.9 % in Tasmania. The Territory's exceptionally strong working-age ratio reflects its resource-driven

economy and relatively high birth rate, while Tasmania's lower figure highlights its appeal as a retirement haven and the out-migration of younger cohorts.

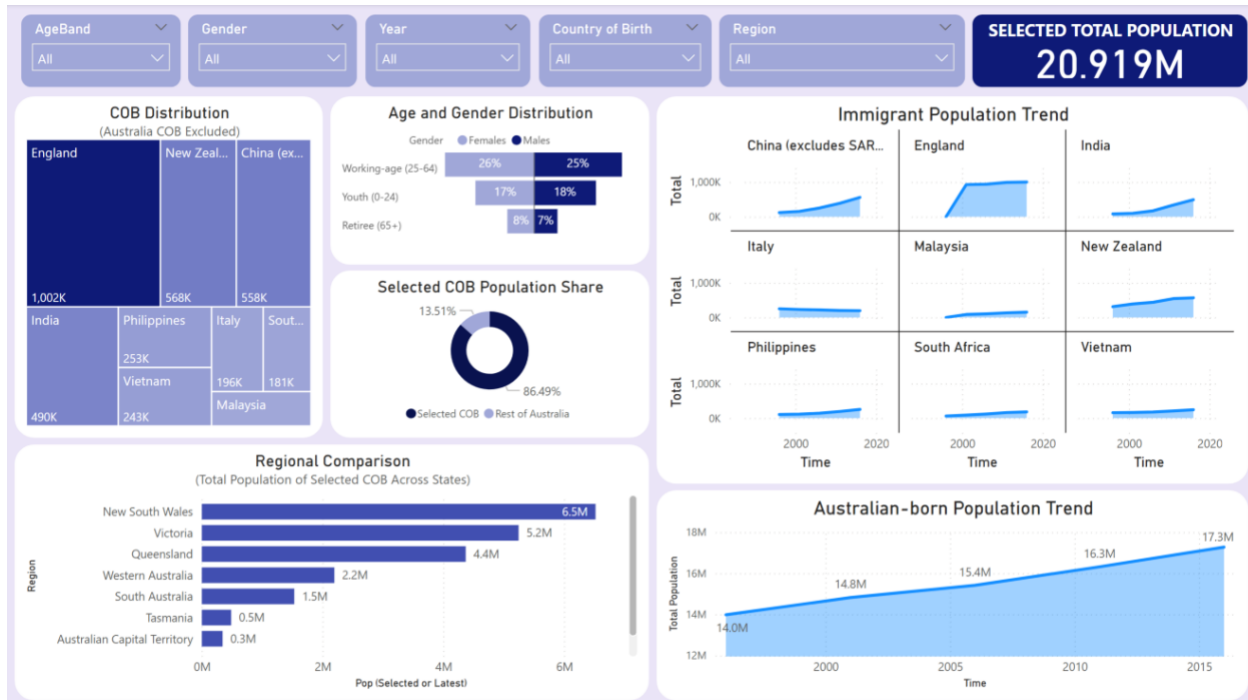
Directly beneath the working-age band, the youth share (0 - 24 yrs) also varied by nearly five percentage points from 35.4 % in the Northern Territory to only 30.3 % in Tasmania underscoring regional differences in family formation and early-career migration.

Conversely, Tasmania led all jurisdictions in retiree proportion at 18.8 %, followed by South Australia (17.7 %) and New South Wales (15.7 %), whereas the Northern Territory's retiree share was the smallest at just 6.9 %. These patterns carry significant implications for state-level service planning: high retiree concentrations in Tasmania and SA will drive demand for health and aged care, while the NT's young demographic will require investments in schools, infrastructure, and entry-level jobs.

2. Most High Populated COB Analysis

2.1 Comparison of Australian-born and Immigrant Population Trends

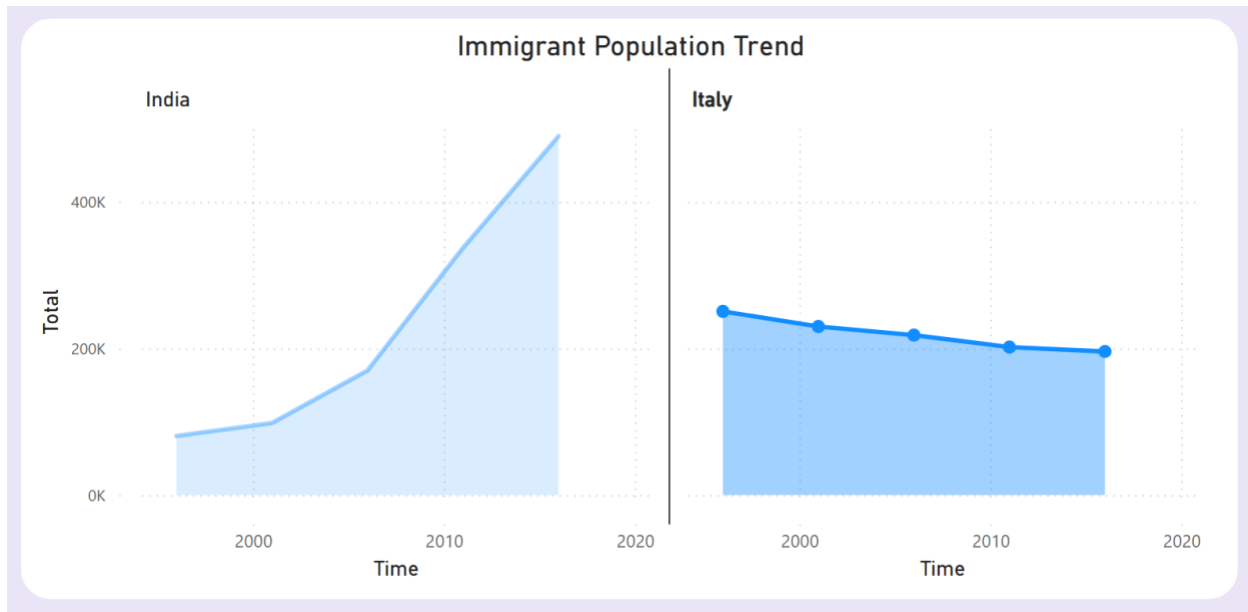
Figure 4: Australian and Immigrant Population Trend



Australia's population surge over the past two decades has been powered overwhelmingly by immigration rather than natural increase. Between 1996 and 2016 the Australian-born population climbed by roughly 3.3 million (a 24 percent rise), but the immigrant cohort from our Top-10 countries exploded by 2.6 million more than doubling (+234 percent) and contributing nearly 80 percent of the nation's total growth. Notably, immigrant growth was front-loaded in the first five years (1996 - 2001), reflecting policy shifts and global migration patterns, and has remained robust ever since, adding between 450 000 and 600 000 newcomers each five-year census interval. In contrast, native-born increases have followed a steadier, more gradual trajectory. According to Kemeny (2016), these divergent curves underscore that Australia's future workforce, cultural mix, and regional development will be shaped far more by incoming residents than by births alone making migration policy the linchpin of long-term demographic planning.

2.2 India Leads a Migration Surge, While Italy's Community Contracts

Figure 5. India vs Italy Population Growth Trend



Between the 2001 and 2016 censuses, India-born residents grew by 391 240 people, jumping from 98 280 to 489 520 a 398 % increase that outstripped every other overseas-born group. China-born Australians also saw substantial growth of 404 380 (≈ 264 %), while the Philippines climbed 120 800 (≈ 121 %). In stark contrast, the Italy-born community shrunk by 59 570 people (-25.9 %), reflecting the maturation and aging of that cohort. This divergence highlights Australia's shifting migrant profile: fast-rising Asian flows versus a plateauing European legacy.

2.3 New South Wales and Victoria Dominate, But New Zealanders Buck the Trend

Examining the 2016 state distribution for each COB reveals a pronounced geographic clustering. China-born Australians are most concentrated in New South Wales, with 45.9 % residing there, and India-born Australians likewise cluster in Victoria (37.4 %). Most European communities (England 25.0 %, South Africa 26.4 %) also peak in NSW, while Italy-born Australians show their greatest proportion in Victoria (40.4 %). An exception is the New Zealand-born group: 38.7 % live in Queensland, making QLD its foremost destination a reminder that not all migrant flows follow the Sydney-Melbourne axis.

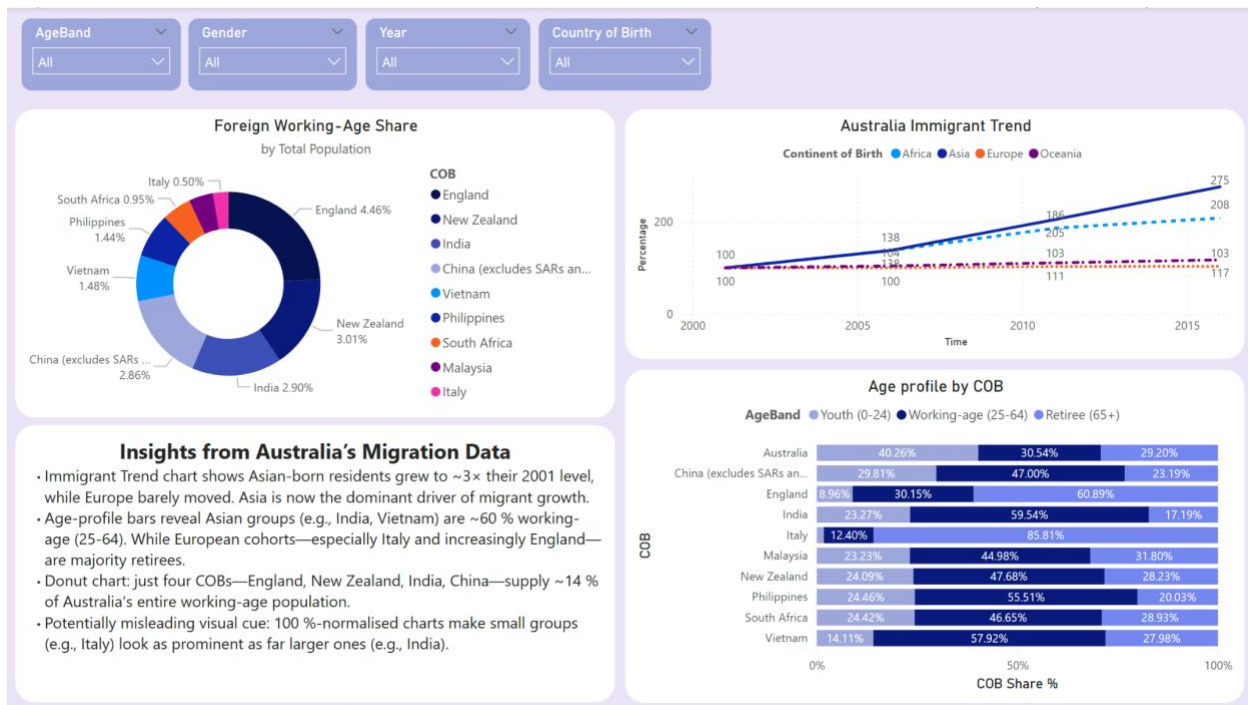
2.4 Clustering vs. Dispersion: Which Communities Spread Out?

Beyond single-state peaks, the degree of concentration varies widely. The Italy-born community is the most tightly clustered, with 40.4 % of its members in Victoria alone, whereas larger groups like China and India despite their size are comparatively dispersed (NSW share 45.9 % and VIC share 37.4 %, respectively). Meanwhile, South African migrants show a more even spread across states, with their top-state share at just 26.4 %. According to Shields et al.

(2016), understanding these patterns is crucial for state governments planning settlement services: highly clustered communities may require focused local support, whereas dispersed populations demand broader, multi-jurisdictional initiatives.

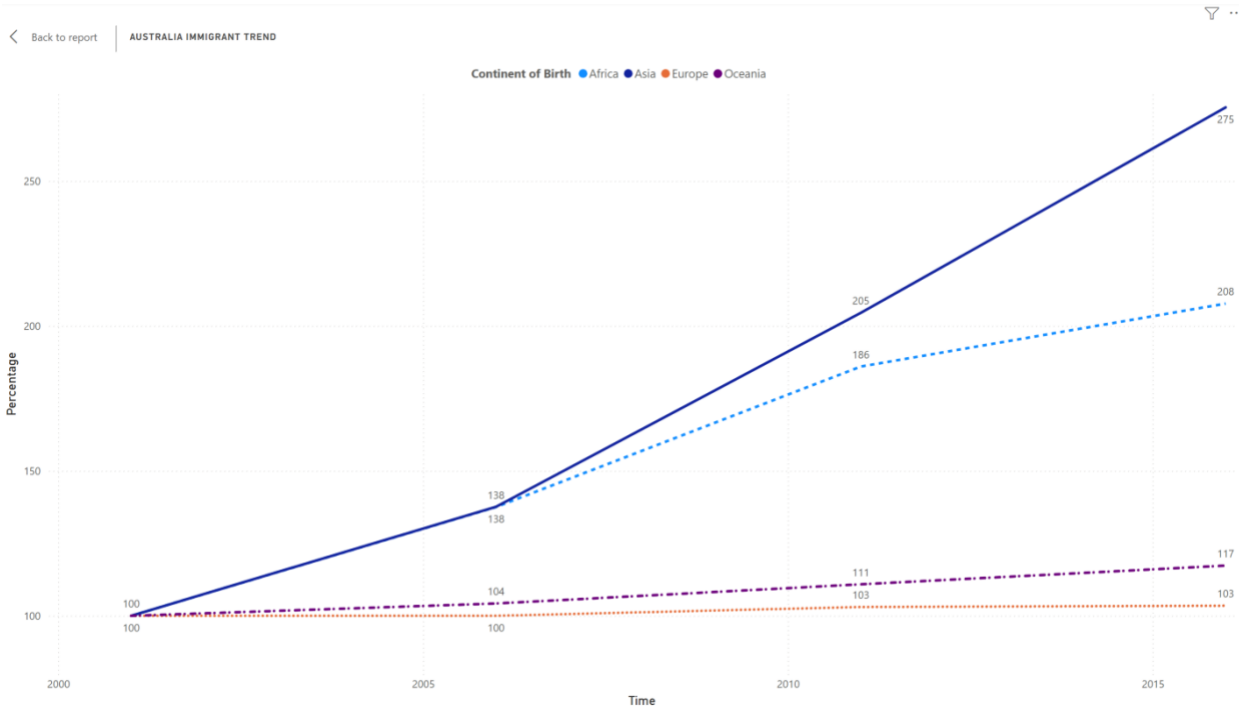
3. Interesting Aspects: Migration Trends and Demographic Profiles

Figure 6. Working-Age Group and Immigrant Trend



3.1 Asia’s Migrant Boom Fuels National Growth

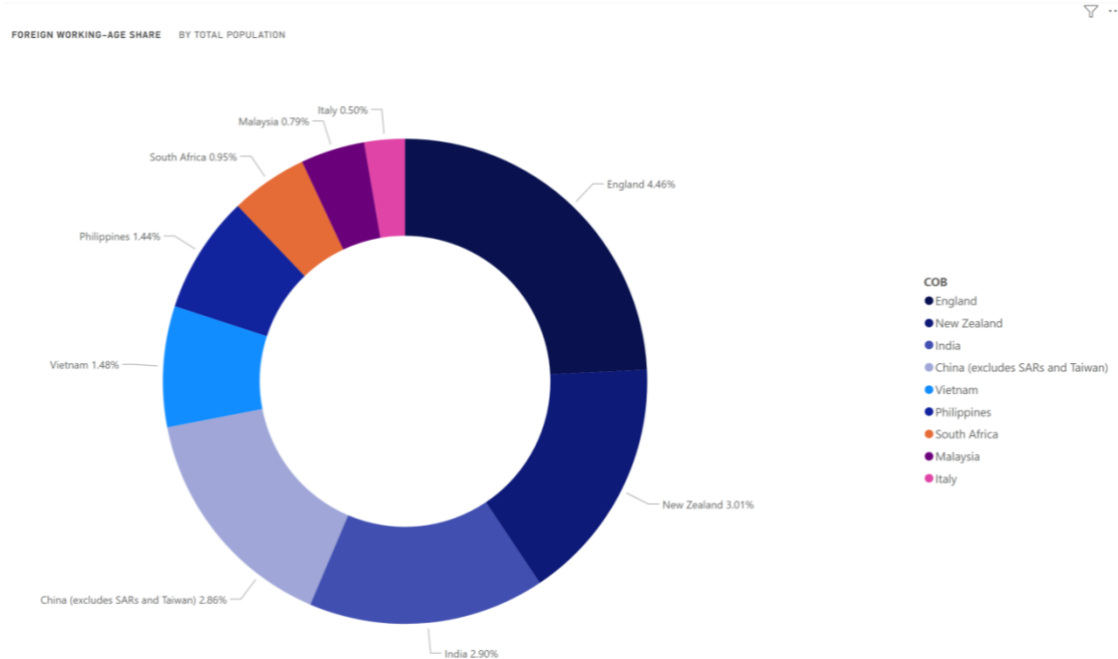
Figure 7. Immigrant by Continent of Birth Population Growth Trend



The Australia Immigrant Trend line chart starkly illustrates Asia’s outsized contribution to Australia’s migrant inflow. Indexed to 100 in 2001, Asian-born residents surged to 275 by 2016 nearly a three-fold increase whereas Europe-born arrivals inches to just 103, and Oceania (largely New Zealand) reached 117. Even Africa-born migrants, at 208, grew at less than half Asia’s pace. This discrepancy underscores a fundamental shift: today’s migrant streams are dominated by Asian source countries, reshaping Australia’s cultural and economic landscape far more dramatically than century-old European networks.

3.2 Working-Age Migrants: A Critical Workforce Share

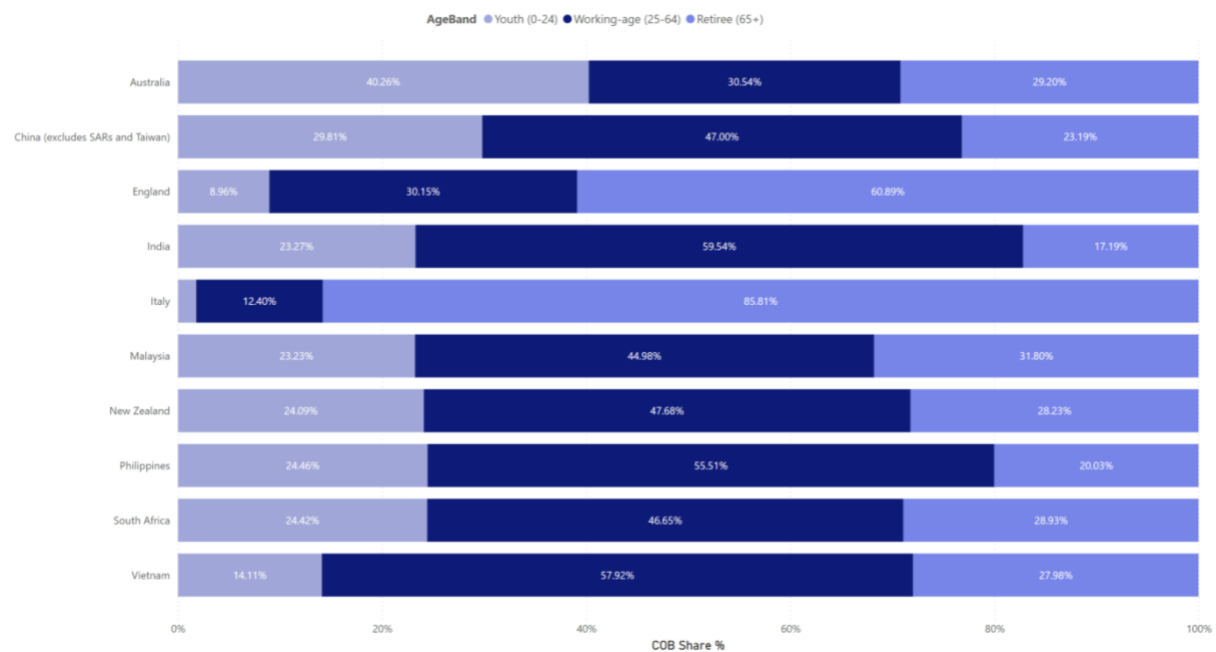
Figure 8. Foreign Working-Age Share (by Total Australia Population)



When measured against Australia's entire population, the Foreign Working-Age Share donut reveals just how integral overseas-born adults are to the labour force. England-born working-age migrants alone account for 4.46 % of all Australians, followed by New Zealand (3.01 %), India (2.90 %), and China (2.86 %). Collectively, these nine source countries represent roughly 17.4 % of Australia's total population in the 25 - 64 age bracket. In other words, nearly one in six working-age residents arrived from just these four countries, highlighting how dependent Australia's economy is on a small set of migrant origins.

3.3 Demographic Contrasts Among Migrant Cohorts

Figure 9. Main Age Group Profile by COB



The Age Profile by COB stacked bars expose dramatic differences in cohort composition. Italy-born Australians are overwhelmingly retirees (85.8 %), while England-born tilt even more heavily toward the 65+ group (60.9 %), reflecting older post-war migration waves. In stark contrast, Philippines (55.5 % working-age) and Vietnam-born (57.9 %) migrants overwhelmingly sit in the 25 - 64 bracket, and China-born have a balanced profile (47 % working-age, 29.8 % youth). According to Kingston et al. (2018), this diversity of age structures signals that policy needs from aged care to schooling must be finely tuned for each community's unique lifecycle stage.

3.4 Emerging Patterns and Policy Implications

Combining all three visuals leads to a clear policy takeaway: Australia's population trajectory hinges on younger, faster-growing Asian cohorts who supply the bulk of its workforce. The immigrant trend shows that Asia is the new migration powerhouse; the working-age share confirms these arrivals form the lion's share of adults in employment; and the age-profile chart warns that reliance on older European communities will not address future labour-market gaps. To sustain economic growth and social services, as suggested by AboElsoud et al. (2020), Australia must continue to cultivate diverse migration streams particularly from Asia while also preparing for the retirement surge among legacy European migrants.

4. Synthesis & Implications

4.1 Synthesis

Australia's demographic landscape from 1996 to 2016 reveals two intertwined dynamics: uneven regional growth and migration-driven population change. On the one hand, Victoria, New South Wales and Queensland accounted for almost 80 percent of the national increase, while Tasmania and the Northern Territory barely budged. Meanwhile, although retirees over 65 now represent 15.2 percent of all Australians and elder women outnumber elder men by roughly 8.1 percent to 7.1 percent the working-age group remains just over 50 percent, preserving Australia's core workforce.

On the other hand, the surge in overseas-born residents especially from Asia has been the primary engine of growth. Immigrants from our Top-10 COBs added 2.6 million people (+234 percent), compared with 3.3 million among the native-born (+24 percent). India alone grew by 398 percent, and Asian-born migrants now contribute nearly 70 percent of the foreign working-age share. State-by-state age profiles further underscore the policy challenge: resource-rich jurisdictions (Kulik et al., 2014) like the Northern Territory remain unusually youthful, whereas Tasmania's 18.8 percent retiree share signals mounting aged-care pressures.

4.2 Implications

Implications for Infrastructure and Services: According to Wiewiora et al. (2015), the stark regional disparities in population growth mean that state and territory governments must tailor infrastructure investments to their unique demographic trajectories. Fast-growing jurisdictions such as Victoria, New South Wales and Queensland require accelerated expansion of housing stock, public transport networks and educational facilities to accommodate surging numbers of young families and working-age migrants. By contrast, Tasmania and the Northern Territory where population gains were minimal can prioritize the refurbishment and optimization of existing assets rather than large-scale new builds.

Health and Aged-Care Planning: With retirees now representing over 18 percent of Tasmania's population and nearly 17 percent in South Australia, the demand for aged-care services, chronic-disease management and supportive housing will continue to rise sharply in those regions. Policymakers must allocate additional health-workforce resources and develop innovative care models such as telehealth and community-based outreach to meet the specific needs of an ageing society (Genge et al., 2023).

Migration Policy and Workforce Strategy: Given that immigrants contributed nearly 80 percent of total population growth and that Asia-born cohorts supply the lion's share of working-age residents federal migration policies should focus on streamlining pathways for skilled migrants from high-growth source countries. At the same time, efforts to diversify migrant origins by incentivizing arrivals from underrepresented regions can reduce overconcentration and strengthen social cohesion (Reid Bell et al., 2019).

Conclusion

The Power BI analysis underscores that Australia's recent population growth is unevenly distributed across states and overwhelmingly driven by immigration particularly from Asia. While the working-age cohort still dominates nationally, ageing pressures vary regionally and by country of birth. These nuanced patterns demand differentiated policy responses: targeted infrastructure expansion in fast-growing states; aged-care capacity in retiree-heavy regions; and refined migration strategies to sustain workforce vitality. By marrying interactive dashboards with clear narrative, this report equips decision makers with the evidence needed to align resources, refine policy levers and anticipate the next phase of Australia's demographic evolution.

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